in rage and fury. The elephants wore armour and had daggers and spears attached to their lashing trunks and 30,000 ‘pugnacious Rajput and Afghan horsemen’ galloped in front of them. Hemu led the charge himself, seated upon his elephant Hawai, as he screamed out his war cry, ‘Band o Bastan’*! His left wing was led by his nephew Ramya while the great Afghan amirs of the Surs rode on elephants picked especially for their courage. As the mass of elephants, black clouds glittering with armour and wicked knives, charged the Mughal army with horrifying speed, the Mughal forces were thrown into pandemonium and disarray. Riders struggled to control horses that had never confronted elephants and the Mughal amirs died in large numbers at the hands of their foe, ‘their blood-dripping blades like hungry lions’. Screaming horses were lifted off the ground by the elephants and flung onto the earth, glossy with blood. The Mughal army numbered 10,000 soldiers but a scathing Abu’l Fazl deemed that only 5,000 were worthy of the designation. They swung their deadly scimitars and the archers wielded their composite bows* but had it not been for a chance arrow which struck Hemu through the eye in the heat of the battle, Bairam Khan’s gamble to confront Hemu’s army may have had a very different outcome.

Seeing their general slumped in his howdah on Hawai, Hemu’s Afghan amirs and soldiers lost heart and the battle was won for the Mughals. Hemu was brought to the Mughal camp, limp and bloodied, but alive. Bairam Khan wanted Akbar to kill Hemu himself, thus eliminating a dangerous foe and earning the title ghazi, slayer of infidels. We will never be sure if Akbar obeyed or not, for according to Abu’l Fazl’s writings, which were closely monitored by Akbar himself decades later, Akbar refused to kill a wounded enemy. But was the fourteen-year-old able to articulate this to his formidable ataliq who had just won a famous victory or were these, in fact, the compassionate thoughts of the fifty-year-old Padshah? Abu’l Fazl writes that he wishes that Akbar had ‘unveiled’ his true nature and not allowed Hemu to have been killed at all, since such a brave and worthy opponent could have been won over and made an honoured member of the Mughal court. In just a few years, diplomacy alongside martial strength would, in fact, become the keystone of Akbar’s policy, allowing him to establish one of the largest empires ever seen in Hindustan. But at fourteen, Akbar was only beginning his extraordinary journey. In any event, Hemu was slain, with Akbar probably striking a blow, and his head was sent to Kabul as a